

German Noun Suffixes & Prefixes

The definitive guide to gender determination (*der, die, das*), linguistic origins, semantic modifications, and high-frequency vocabulary.

The Golden Gender Rule: "*Der Suffix bestimmt das Genus.*" (The suffix dictates grammatical gender). While root nouns can have unpredictable genders, any German noun bearing a standard suffix follows its gender rule with near 100% accuracy.

1. Masculine Noun Suffixes (der)

Always masculine (~100%)

Suffix	Function / Origin	German Examples & English Meaning
-ant	Active person / agent (Latin origin)	der Praktikant (<i>intern</i>), der Demonstrant (<i>protester</i>), der Musikant (<i>musician</i>), der Lieferant (<i>supplier</i>)
-ent	Person / agent / role (Latin origin)	der Student (<i>student</i>), der Präsident (<i>president</i>), der Patient (<i>patient</i>), der Dozent (<i>lecturer</i>)
-ar / -är	Profession / social role	der Bibliothekar (<i>librarian</i>), der Notar (<i>notary</i>), der Sekretär (<i>secretary</i>), der Millionär (<i>millionaire</i>)
-ast	Person engaged in activity	der Gymnasiast (<i>high school student</i>), der Enthusiast (<i>enthusiast</i>), der Fantast (<i>dreamer</i>)
-eur	Profession / agent (French loan)	der Friseur (<i>hairdresser</i>), der Ingenieur (<i>engineer</i>), der Masseur (<i>masseur</i>), der Regisseur (<i>director</i>)
-or	Agent, technical instrument, role	der Motor (<i>motor/engine</i>), der Professor (<i>professor</i>), der Reaktor (<i>reactor</i>), der Autor (<i>author</i>), der Faktor (<i>factor</i>)
-ist	Practitioner, believer, profession	der Polizist (<i>police officer</i>), der Tourist (<i>tourist</i>), der Journalist (<i>journalist</i>), der Optimist (<i>optimist</i>)
-ismus	Ideology, doctrine, system (-ism)	der Kapitalismus (<i>capitalism</i>), der Optimismus (<i>optimism</i>), der Tourismus (<i>tourism</i>), der Realismus (<i>realism</i>)
-ling	Individual with a specific trait / origin	der Lehrling (<i>apprentice</i>), der Schmetterling (<i>butterfly</i>), der Zwilling (<i>twin</i>), der Frühling (<i>spring</i>), der Flüchtling (<i>refugee</i>)
-ich / -ig	Concrete items, animals, substances	der Teppich (<i>carpet</i>), der Kranich (<i>crane</i>), der Honig (<i>honey</i>), der König (<i>king</i>), der Essig (<i>vinegar</i>), der Käfig (<i>cage</i>)
-us	State, cycle, scientific concept	der Rhythmus (<i>rhythm</i>), der Zirkus (<i>circus</i>), der Status (<i>status</i>), der Zyklus (<i>cycle</i>)
-er	Doer of action, origin, device	der Lehrer (<i>teacher</i>), der Fahrer (<i>driver</i>), der Bäcker (<i>baker</i>), der Computer (<i>computer</i>) (Exceptions: <i>das Fenster, das Zimmer, die Mutter, die Schwester</i>)

2. Feminine Noun Suffixes (die)

Always feminine (~100%)

Suffix	Function / Origin	German Examples & English Meaning
-ung	Action, process, result (English "-ing")	die Wohnung (<i>apartment</i>), die Zeitung (<i>newspaper</i>), die Rechnung (<i>invoice/bill</i>), die Hoffnung (<i>hope</i>), die Erfahrung (<i>experience</i>)
-heit	Condition, state, quality (from adj.)	die Freiheit (<i>freedom</i>), die Gesundheit (<i>health</i>), die Schönheit (<i>beauty</i>), die Wahrheit (<i>truth</i>), die Einheit (<i>unity</i>)

Suffix	Function / Origin	German Examples & English Meaning
-keit	State, trait (added to adj. in -ig/-lich)	die Möglichkeit (<i>possibility</i>), die Einsamkeit (<i>loneliness</i>), die Sauberkeit (<i>cleanliness</i>), die Pünktlichkeit (<i>punctuality</i>)
-schaft	Collective, relationship (English "-ship")	die Freundschaft (<i>friendship</i>), die Mannschaft (<i>team</i>), die Gesellschaft (<i>society</i>), die Landschaft (<i>landscape</i>)
-tät	Abstract quality (English "-ty")	die Universität (<i>university</i>), die Qualität (<i>quality</i>), die Realität (<i>reality</i>), die Identität (<i>identity</i>)
-ion	Action, process, institution (Latin)	die Nation (<i>nation</i>), die Information (<i>information</i>), die Diskussion (<i>discussion</i>), die Religion (<i>religion</i>)
-ur	Result, form, structure (English "-ure")	die Natur (<i>nature</i>), die Kultur (<i>culture</i>), die Figur (<i>figure</i>), die Struktur (<i>structure</i>), die Reparatur (<i>repair</i>)
-ik	Science, art, system (English "-ics")	die Musik (<i>music</i>), die Politik (<i>politics</i>), die Grammatik (<i>grammar</i>), die Fabrik (<i>factory</i>), die Logik (<i>logic</i>)
-ei / -erei	Place of business, annoying repetition	die Bäckerei (<i>bakery</i>), die Bücherei (<i>library</i>), die Metzgerei (<i>butcher shop</i>), die Quälerei (<i>hassle/agony</i>)
-in	Female counterpart (plural: -innen)	die Lehrerin (<i>female teacher</i>), die Ärztin (<i>female doctor</i>), die Studentin (<i>female student</i>), die Chefin (<i>female boss</i>)
-anz / -enz	State, property (English "-ance / -ence")	die Toleranz (<i>tolerance</i>), die Eleganz (<i>elegance</i>), die Konferenz (<i>conference</i>), die Existenz (<i>existence</i>)
-ade / -age	Action, beverage, installation	die Schokolade (<i>chocolate</i>), die Marmelade (<i>jam</i>), die Garage (<i>garage</i>), die Montage (<i>assembly</i>)
-ie / -ive	Fields of study, collective initiatives	die Energie (<i>energy</i>), die Philosophie (<i>philosophy</i>), die Initiative (<i>initiative</i>), die Perspektive (<i>perspective</i>)
-e	~90% of two-syllable nouns ending in -e	die Liebe (<i>love</i>), die Sonne (<i>sun</i>), die Lampe (<i>lamp</i>), die Reise (<i>trip</i>) (Exceptions: n-nouns like <i>der Name</i> , <i>der Junge</i> ; neuter: <i>das Auge</i> , <i>das Ende</i>)

3. Neuter Noun Suffixes (das)

Always neuter (~100%)

Suffix	Function / Origin	German Examples & English Meaning
-chen	Diminutive (makes small/cute) + Umlaut	das Mädchen (<i>girl</i>), das Brötchen (<i>bread roll</i>), das Häuschen (<i>little house</i>), das Kätzchen (<i>kitten</i>)
-lein	Diminutive (poetic/regional) + Umlaut	das Fräulein (<i>young lady</i>), das Büchlein (<i>booklet</i>), das Sternlein (<i>little star</i>), das Kindlein (<i>little child</i>)
-ment	Result, object, institution (Latin/French)	das Dokument (<i>document</i>), das Instrument (<i>instrument</i>), das Experiment (<i>experiment</i>), das Parlament (<i>parliament</i>)
-um	Institution, scientific field (Latin)	das Zentrum (<i>center</i>), das Museum (<i>museum</i>), das Datum (<i>date</i>), das Studium (<i>university studies</i>), das Universum (<i>universe</i>)
-tum	State, status, collective realm (-dom)	das Eigentum (<i>property</i>), das Christentum (<i>Christianity</i>), das Wachstum (<i>growth</i>) (Key Exceptions: der Reichtum [wealth], der Irrtum [error])
-ma	Concepts & scientific terms (Greek origin)	das Thema (<i>topic/theme</i>), das Klima (<i>climate</i>), das Drama (<i>drama</i>), das Schema (<i>scheme/pattern</i>)
-ing	Modern loan nouns (English gerunds)	das Training (<i>training/workout</i>), das Meeting (<i>meeting</i>), das Timing (<i>timing</i>), das Recycling (<i>recycling</i>)
-o	International loanwords	das Auto (<i>car</i>), das Foto (<i>photo</i>), das Radio (<i>radio</i>), das Kino (<i>cinema</i>), das Büro (<i>office</i>)

4. Variable Gender Suffixes (-nis & -sal)

Dual distribution (Neuter vs. Feminine)

Suffix	Neuter Forms (das) — Majority	Feminine Forms (die) — Minority
-nis	das Geheimnis (<i>secret</i>) das Ergebnis (<i>result</i>) das Zeugnis (<i>certificate</i>) das Erlebnis (<i>experience</i>) das Gefängnis (<i>prison</i>)	die Erlaubnis (<i>permission</i>) die Kenntnis (<i>knowledge</i>) die Finsternis (<i>darkness</i>) die Wildnis (<i>wilderness</i>) die Besorgnis (<i>worry/concern</i>)
-sal	das Schicksal (<i>destiny / fate</i>) das Rätsel (<i>puzzle / riddle</i>)	die Mühsal (<i>hardship / toil</i>) die Trübsal (<i>gloom / sorrow</i>)

5. German Noun Prefixes (Vorsilben)

Modifies meaning, scale & status

Prefix	Semantic Meaning	German Examples & English Meaning
Ur-	Original, primeval, first, ancient	der Urwald (<i>jungle/primeval forest</i>), die Ursache (<i>original cause</i>), der Ursprung (<i>origin</i>), die Urgroßmutter (<i>great-grandmother</i>)
Un-	Negation, bad, monstrous, opposite	das Unglück (<i>misfortune</i>), die Unruhe (<i>turmoil</i>), der Unsinn (<i>nonsense</i>), das Unwetter (<i>severe storm</i>), das Unkraut (<i>weed</i>)
Miss-	Mistaken, failed, bad (English "mis-")	das Missverständnis (<i>misunderstanding</i>), der Misserfolg (<i>failure</i>), der Missbrauch (<i>abuse</i>), das Misstrauen (<i>distrust</i>)
Fehl-	Error, deficit, false, failed	der Fehlalarm (<i>false alarm</i>), die Fehlentscheidung (<i>wrong decision</i>), der Fehlschlag (<i>failure</i>), der Fehlbetrag (<i>deficit</i>)
Haupt-	Primary, chief, main, head	die Hauptstadt (<i>capital city</i>), der Hauptbahnhof (<i>main train station</i>), die Hauptrolle (<i>lead role</i>), das Hauptproblem (<i>main problem</i>)
Neben-	Secondary, side, minor	die Nebenwirkung (<i>side effect</i>), der Nebenjob (<i>part-time side job</i>), das Nebengebäude (<i>annex</i>), die Nebenrolle (<i>supporting role</i>)

Prefix	Semantic Meaning	German Examples & English Meaning
Erz-	Arch-, chief, extreme, supreme	der Erzbischof (<i>archbishop</i>), der Erzengel (<i>archangel</i>), der Erzfeind (<i>archenemy</i>), der Erzrivale (<i>archrival</i>)
Vize- / Ex-	Deputy / Former (previous title)	der Vizepräsident (<i>vice president</i>), der Vizekanzler (<i>vice chancellor</i>), der Ex-Mann (<i>ex-husband</i>), der Ex-Chef (<i>former boss</i>)
Vor- / Nach-	Pre / Before — Post / After	das Vorurteil (<i>prejudice</i>), die Vorfreude (<i>anticipation</i>) • der Nachmittag (<i>afternoon</i>), der Nachgeschmack (<i>aftertaste</i>)
Mit- / Gegen-	Fellow / Partner — Counter / Opposed	der Mitarbeiter (<i>employee/colleague</i>), der Mitbewohner (<i>roommate</i>) • der Gegenstand (<i>object</i>), das Gegenteil (<i>opposite</i>)
Ge- (Collective)	Aggregated collection → ALWAYS das	das Gebirge (<i>mountain range</i>), das Gebäude (<i>building</i>), das Gepäck (<i>luggage</i>), das Geschirr (<i>dishes</i>), das Gemüse (<i>vegetables</i>)
Riesen- / Super-	Colossal / Extreme intensity	der Riesenerfolg (<i>massive success</i>), der Riesen hunger (<i>ravenous hunger</i>), der Supermarkt (<i>supermarket</i>)

DER (Masculine)

-ant, -ent, -ar, -är
-ast, -eur, -or, -ist
-ismus, -ling, -ich
-ig, -us, -er (agent)

DIE (Feminine)

-ung, -heit, -keit
-schaft, -tät, -ion
-ur, -ik, -ei, -in
-anz, -enz, -ade, -e (90%)

DAS (Neuter)

-chen, -lein (diminutive)
-ment, -um, -tum
-ma, -ing, -o
Prefix **Ge-** (collective)